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# Does AI Overshadow the Product? Evidence from the Audiobook Market

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**Abstract.** Amazon's Virtual Voice program created the first mass market in which AI narrates human-written books under a label and each title, whether human- or AI-narrated, is rated separately on the dimension the narrator performs (Performance) and the dimension the author writes (Story). I exploit this attribute-split rating system in a census of Audible's 656,155 English-language audiobooks, 103,711 of them AI-narrated. The market's response is not a blanket rejection: the discount lands almost entirely on Performance ( $-0.65$  stars with controls) while Story is statistically indistinguishable from zero, and the same split holds within author ( $-0.73$  on Performance,  $-0.08$  on Story). In the small licensed-clone channel, where professional narrators lend their voices under contract, early evidence finds no such discount, suggesting it attaches to the anonymous channel rather than to AI as such. AI narration reached 47% of new 2025 English-language releases, most of it from authors without an earlier human-narrated book; yet among 2024–25 releases only 0.1% of AI-narrated titles have reached 200 ratings, against 7.2% of human-narrated ones. Whatever mix of true quality and label response drives the Performance discount, it stops at the AI's attribute: the market prices the AI's contribution, not the AI.

**Key words:** generative AI; AI disclosure; voice cloning; online ratings; creative industries; algorithm aversion

## 1. Introduction

In November 2023, Amazon began offering self-published authors a way to turn an e-book into an audiobook without hiring a narrator: a synthetic voice reads the text, and the title sells on Audible alongside human-narrated books ([Amazon Kindle Direct Publishing 2023](#), [Publishers Weekly 2023](#)). By 2025, AI narration accounted for 47.4% of the platform's new English-language releases (Figure 1), and every such title is credited to its synthetic narrator on the product page. Audiobooks are thus the first mass market in which AI performs human-authored work under a label, at scale, and where the market's own ratings score the narration separately from the writing. Whether such content arrives is no longer the open question. What remains open is where the market's response lands: on the product as a whole, or only on the AI's contribution to it.

Audible's rating system splits the evaluation along exactly the line the question requires. AI enters the product at a single step, the narration, while the writing remains the author's. Every title is rated separately, on the same five-star scale, for Performance, the narration, and for Story, the writing, both scored by the same audience for the same product. The AI supply also divides into two labeled channels: anonymous synthetic voices with no performer behind them, and licensed clones that carry a professional narrator's name. I take a census of the store and analyze its 656,155 English-language audiobooks, 103,711 of them AI-narrated.

Four patterns emerge. First, in counts, AI narration is additive entry: human-narrated output has not retreated, and most AI titles come from authors with no earlier human-narrated audiobook. Second, the evaluation is split, not blanket: with controls, AI-narrated books lose 0.65 stars on Performance, the dimension the AI performs, while Story ratings move little or not at all, and the same split holds within author. Third, the author's reputation does not blunt the discount, which tracks the channel instead, concentrating on anonymous voices, while licensed clones show, on early evidence, no comparable discount. Fourth, the flood is absorbed without breakout: AI-narrated

books almost never become widely rated titles, while human-narrated books regularly do. In short, the market's evaluative response lands not on the product as a whole but on the AI's contribution to it.

One literature isolates the label. Since [Dietvorst et al. \(2015\)](#) named algorithm aversion, experiments have held quality fixed, varied only what evaluators are told, and found resistance to AI provision that persists even at identical performance ([Longoni et al. 2019](#)); in the closest antecedent to my setting, a blind preference for AI-generated content erodes once its origin is revealed ([Parshakov et al. 2025](#)). Whether that response governs a real market, at scale and with quality free to vary, is a question those designs cannot answer. The other literature reaches the market but not the structure of its response: LLM-written books, detected rather than disclosed, nearly tripled entry on Amazon while concentrating at the low-usage end of the market ([Reimers and Waldfogel 2026](#)); labeled AI images expanded a stock-image marketplace while crowding out non-AI supply ([Goldberg and Lam 2026](#)); on a large Chinese audio platform, AI entry shifted listening away from human-narrated titles ([Wan et al. 2024](#)); and generative AI cut demand for exposed freelance creative work ([Demirci et al. 2025](#)). None of these settings rates the AI's contribution and the human's separately for the same product, and none observes a licensed channel that unbundles the technology from anonymity. The audiobook market has both, which is why it can show not only whether labeled AI content is discounted, but what the discount is a discount on.

My estimates are equilibrium measurements, in the descriptive tradition of large-scale studies of newly opened AI channels ([Kaiser and Schulze 2026](#)). Authors choose whether, and for which books, to adopt AI narration, so the estimates describe the market as it operates, not the effect of assigning a book to an AI voice. The Performance discount itself is a mixture: it bundles true quality differences with whatever response the visible label provokes, and my data do not separate the two. The paper's claims survive that ambiguity: wherever the discount comes from, what I establish is

where it stops. Clone parity, likewise, is early evidence from a small, publisher-curated channel, and it bundles the narrator's own voice with loyal audiences and the curation itself. Ratings, finally, measure expressed evaluations, not demand or welfare. I interpret every result within these limits.

## 2. Data and Empirical Strategy

### 2.1. AI Narration on Audible

AI narration entered the audiobook market through Amazon's self-publishing arm. In November 2023, Kindle Direct Publishing opened Virtual Voice, an invitation-based program that converts an author's eligible e-book into an audiobook read by a generic synthetic voice at no production cost, an arrangement in place from launch through the census date. Authors set the list price and collect royalties, and the titles are sold on Audible, Amazon's audiobook marketplace ([Amazon Kindle Direct Publishing 2023](#), [Publishers Weekly 2023](#)). Disclosure is built in: each product page credits the narrator as "Virtual Voice" (hereafter, AI narration).

Two later programs professionalized the AI supply. In September 2024, Audible's production platform ACX began inviting professional narrators to license *voice replicas*, authorized AI copies of their own voices: rights holders select a replica for a title, the narrator reviews the production and is compensated per title, and the credit names the voice ("X's voice replica") ([ACX 2024](#), [Bloomberg News 2024](#)). In May 2025, Audible extended AI narration to selected publishers, offering more than one hundred synthetic voices across four languages ([Audible 2025](#)). My analysis groups this supply into two channels that consumers can distinguish at the point of purchase: anonymous AI voices, meaning Virtual Voice and other synthetic voices that correspond to no performer, and licensed voice clones, which carry a professional narrator's name.

Audible's rating system is what makes this market a measurement instrument. Every title carries three rating scales: Overall, Performance, and Story. Performance covers the narration and Story the writing. A book's two dimension ratings average over the same audience, so the two are priced side by side for the same product, separating execution from the underlying work in a way a single overall

**Table 1** Summary Statistics, Analysis Sample

|                        | Human-narrated |                    |         |         | AI-narrated |                    |         |         |
|------------------------|----------------|--------------------|---------|---------|-------------|--------------------|---------|---------|
|                        | Mean           | Standard deviation | Minimum | Maximum | Mean        | Standard deviation | Minimum | Maximum |
| Performance rating     | 4.50           | 0.41               | 1       | 5       | 3.88        | 0.63               | 1       | 5       |
| Story rating           | 4.42           | 0.41               | 1       | 5       | 4.34        | 0.49               | 1       | 5       |
| Ratings per book       | 335            | 2,273              | 5       | 301,973 | 20          | 34                 | 5       | 2,021   |
| Runtime (hours)        | 8.35           | 6.01               | 0       | 280     | 6.35        | 6.06               | 0       | 145     |
| Number of narrators    | 1.27           | 1.06               | 1       | 16      | 1.00        | 0.01               | 1       | 2       |
| Self-published         | 0.00           | 0.01               | 0       | 1       | 0.60        | 0.49               | 0       | 1       |
| In a series            | 0.44           | 0.50               | 0       | 1       | 0.00        | 0.03               | 0       | 1       |
| New author (indicator) | 0.28           | 0.45               | 0       | 1       | 0.70        | 0.46               | 0       | 1       |
| Books                  | 382,944        |                    |         |         | 14,578      |                    |         |         |
| Authors                | 115,025        |                    |         |         | 4,752       |                    |         |         |

*Note.* Analysis sample: English-language audiobooks on Audible as of July 2026 with at least five ratings on each dimension; ratings are cumulative averages over the book’s audience. The author is the book’s first-listed writer; the narrator is credited separately (a human performer or an AI voice). Self-published = publisher listed as Independently Published. New author = no human-narrated audiobook released before the given book. AI = Audible Virtual Voice (launched November 2023).

rating cannot; the Overall scale therefore plays no further role in the analysis. For an AI-narrated title, Performance then isolates the AI’s contribution and Story the author’s.

## 2.2. Data

I observe the complete Audible catalog as of July 2026, enumerated from the store’s public sitemap and category listings. The *full sample* contains its 656,155 English-language audiobooks, 103,711 of them AI-narrated. For each title I observe product metadata and, for each rating scale, the cumulative average and the count of ratings; I do not observe individual ratings. The author is the book’s first-listed writer, matched across narration regimes by a normalized name key and verified for authors appearing in both regimes (Online Appendix A.1).

Rating analyses use an *analysis sample* of books with at least five ratings on each dimension: 382,944 human-narrated and 14,578 AI-narrated books (Table 1). The table records the contrasts that motivate my empirical strategy: AI-narrated books are more recent, shorter, overwhelmingly self-published, mostly by authors without an earlier human-narrated book, and have far fewer ratings; the estimators in Section 2.3 are designed so that these observable differences do not pass for a rating discount. Market-level exhibits use the full sample; each exhibit states its sample.

### 2.3. Empirical Strategy

My estimates rest on two nested comparisons, each holding fixed a larger share of what differs between AI-narrated and human-narrated books.

First, the *within-book gap*. For book  $i$  in genre  $g(i)$  and release year  $t(i)$ , I estimate

$$Gap_i = \beta AI_i + \mathbf{X}_i' \boldsymbol{\gamma} + \mu_{g(i)} + \lambda_{t(i)} + \varepsilon_i, \quad (1)$$

where  $Gap_i$  is the book's Performance rating minus its Story rating,  $AI_i$  indicates AI narration, and  $\mathbf{X}_i$  collects log rating volume, runtime, a self-published indicator, and a series indicator. Both dimension ratings of a book aggregate essentially the same audience: within a book, the two rating counts are nearly identical, with a median difference of zero. Equation (1) is therefore equivalent to a book fixed-effects specification on the stacked dimension ratings. Factors that operate at the book level, including selection into the book's audience, that audience's overall generosity, vintage, price, genre appeal, and demand, all difference out. The controls and fixed effects in equation (1) therefore absorb only differences in the gap itself, such as genres or cohorts whose ratings tilt toward one dimension. I estimate the same specification with Performance and Story themselves as outcomes to show where the gap originates, and in the reported estimates I split the AI coefficient into its two channels.

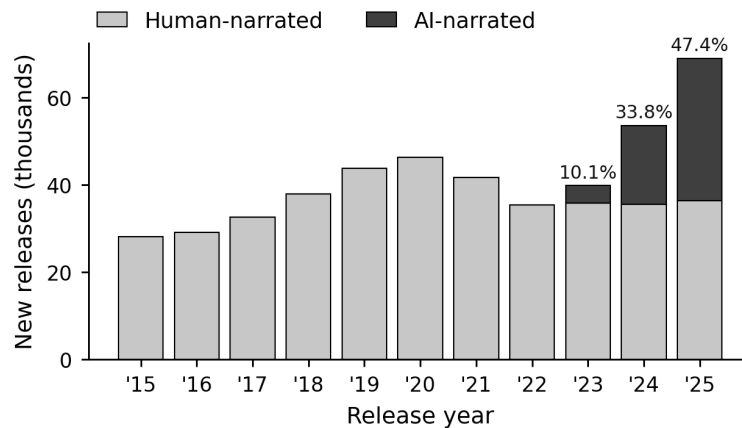
Second, the *within-author discount*. For authors publishing in both narration regimes, I estimate

$$Y_i = \alpha_{a(i)} + \beta AI_i + \mathbf{X}_i' \boldsymbol{\gamma} + \lambda_{t(i)} + \varepsilon_i, \quad (2)$$

for each outcome  $Y \in \{Performance, Story, Gap\}$ , where the author fixed effect  $\alpha_{a(i)}$  holds the author's identity fixed while the narration regime varies. Standard errors are clustered by author throughout.

These comparisons trace the structure of the market's response, not its composition: the Performance discount they recover is a mixture of genuine quality differences and reactions to the visible

**Figure 1** New Audiobook Releases by Narration Regime, 2015–2025



*Note.* New English-language audiobook releases by release year, full sample (the complete Audible catalog as of July 2026); percentages are the AI share of each year's releases. Virtual Voice launched in November 2023; 2026 is omitted as a partial year. Titles are counted as live at the census date, so earlier vintages are lower bounds and recent AI shares are approximate. AI = Audible Virtual Voice.

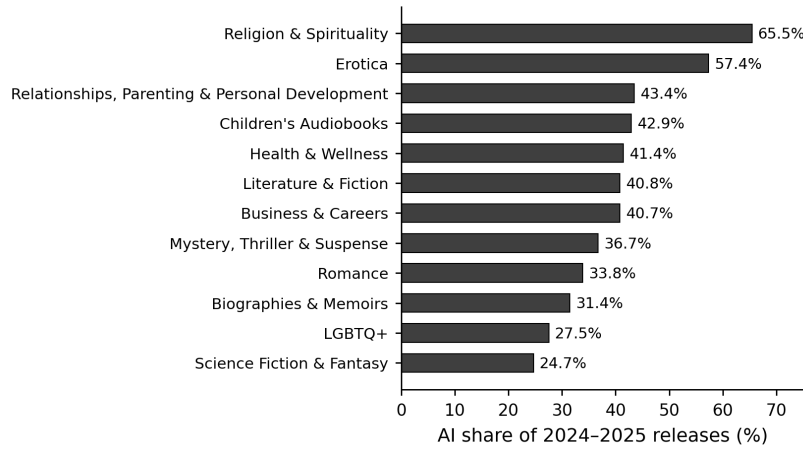
label, and my data do not separate the two. What the design does establish is where the response lands and where it does not.

### 3. Results

#### 3.1. The Flood: Entry Without Narrators

Figure 1 shows the inflow. AI narration launched in November 2023 and reached nearly half of new releases within two years: 4,022 AI-narrated titles in 2023 (10.1% of new English-language releases), 18,117 in 2024 (33.8%), and 32,700 in 2025 (47.4%). Human-narrated output did not retreat: roughly 36,000 titles per year across 2023–2025, in line with 2022. In counts, AI narration is additive entry, not displacement.

Figure 2 shows where the inflow concentrates. AI narration reaches all twelve of the largest categories, at depths ranging from 24.7% of new Science Fiction & Fantasy releases to 65.5% of Religion & Spirituality, with Erotica at 57.4%. Literature & Fiction, the largest category, sits at 40.8% and alone contributes 21.8% of AI-narrated output.

**Figure 2** AI Share of New Releases by Category, 2024–2025

*Note.* AI share of 2024–2025 releases within the twelve largest categories by release volume. Categories are each title's primary store category. AI = Audible Virtual Voice.

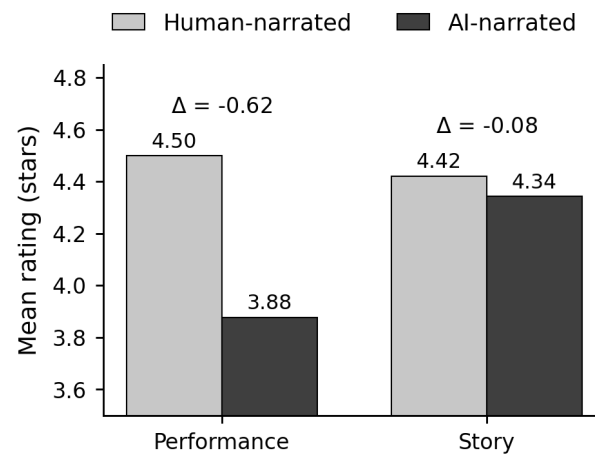
### 3.2. The Bill: Consumers Price the AI's Contribution

Figure 3 shows unadjusted means on the analysis sample. Performance falls from 4.50 on human-narrated books to 3.88 on AI-narrated books; Story falls from 4.42 to 4.34. Before any control, the two dimensions diverge: a drop of 0.62 against one of 0.08.

Table 2 reports the regression estimates. Columns (1)–(3) estimate equation (1) across all books in the analysis sample, splitting the AI coefficient into its two channels. Anonymous AI voices bear a Performance discount of 0.653 stars, a Story coefficient of  $-0.016$  that is statistically indistinguishable from zero, and a within-book gap 0.637 lower. Licensed voice clones show no statistically significant coefficient on any dimension; Section 3.3 returns to them.

Columns (4)–(6) estimate equation (2) on a sharper comparison: they keep only the 1,010 authors who publish both human-narrated and anonymous AI titles and add author fixed effects, so each author's AI-narrated books are compared with the same author's human-narrated books. Within these authors, an AI-narrated book is rated 0.728 lower on Performance and a statistically significant 0.075 lower on Story; the gap estimate of  $-0.653$  is close to its pooled counterpart. Were the discount driven by weaker manuscripts routed to AI narration, Story, the dimension that mea-

**Figure 3** Mean Ratings by Dimension and Narration Regime



*Note.* Mean Performance and Story ratings, analysis sample of Table 1 (382,944 human-narrated and 14,578 AI-narrated books). Within a book, both dimension ratings average over the same audience. The y-axis is truncated (3.5–4.85) for readability. AI = Audible Virtual Voice.

sure the writing, would fall by more than Performance rather than by roughly a tenth as much. Manuscript writing quality thus explains little of the Performance discount. The diagnostic speaks to the writing; it does not rule out selection on unobserved characteristics that matter only for narration. Whichever of mild spillover or residual selection accounts for the remaining Story movement, roughly nine-tenths of the discount sits on the dimension the AI performs. The discount also remains large, and the Performance–Story gap essentially unchanged, when the inclusion threshold rises from five to fifty ratings on each dimension, so containment is not an artifact of the sample cutoff (Online Appendix A.3). The discount concentrates on the dimension the AI performs; the author’s dimension moves little or not at all.

### 3.3. Who Bears the Discount

An AI-narrated book can carry two names: the author’s on the cover and, for licensed clones, the narrator’s on the credit. Table 2 locates the discount on the books that carry only the first: anonymous AI voices bear it; licensed voice clones do not. The two channels also draw on different suppliers. Of the 103,711 AI-narrated titles, anonymous voices account for 103,146 and licensed clones for

**Table 2** The AI-Narration Discount: Pooled and Within-Author Estimates

|                                    | All books            |                   |                          | Authors publishing in both regimes |                      |                          |
|------------------------------------|----------------------|-------------------|--------------------------|------------------------------------|----------------------|--------------------------|
|                                    | (1)<br>Performance   | (2)<br>Story      | (3)<br>Performance–Story | (4)<br>Performance                 | (5)<br>Story         | (6)<br>Performance–Story |
| AI narration, anonymous voice      | -0.653***<br>(0.019) | -0.016<br>(0.015) | -0.637***<br>(0.013)     | -0.728***<br>(0.034)               | -0.075***<br>(0.024) | -0.653***<br>(0.027)     |
| AI narration, licensed voice clone | -0.073<br>(0.045)    | -0.019<br>(0.035) | -0.054<br>(0.044)        |                                    |                      |                          |
| Book controls                      | Yes                  | Yes               | Yes                      | Yes                                | Yes                  | Yes                      |
| Genre fixed effects                | Yes                  | Yes               | Yes                      | No                                 | No                   | No                       |
| Release-year fixed effects         | Yes                  | Yes               | Yes                      | Yes                                | Yes                  | Yes                      |
| Author fixed effects               | No                   | No                | No                       | Yes                                | Yes                  | Yes                      |
| Mean of dependent variable         | 4.476                | 4.418             | 0.058                    | 4.273                              | 4.425                | -0.153                   |
| Observations                       | 397,522              | 397,522           | 397,522                  | 13,795                             | 13,795               | 13,795                   |
| Authors                            | 118,759              | 118,759           | 118,759                  | 1,010                              | 1,010                | 1,010                    |
| Adjusted $R^2$                     | 0.235                | 0.194             | 0.158                    |                                    |                      |                          |
| Within $R^2$                       |                      |                   |                          | 0.298                              | 0.068                | 0.348                    |

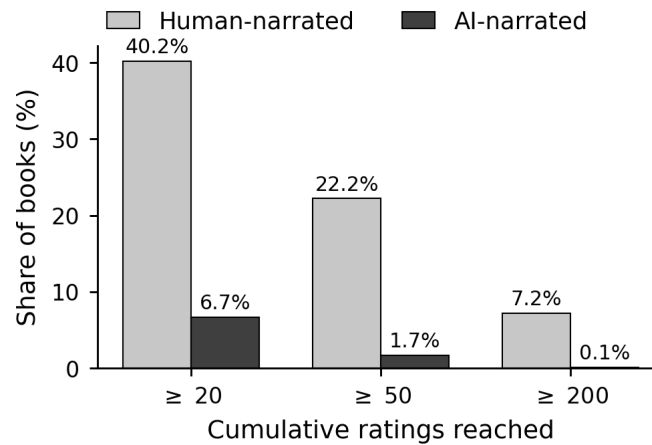
*Note.* Outcomes are Performance and Story ratings on a one-to-five star scale. Each column is one regression on the analysis sample of Table 1. Columns (4)–(6) add author fixed effects and keep the 1,010 authors with both human-narrated and anonymous AI titles (8 further authors, whose only AI titles are clones, enter columns (1)–(3) only); no licensed-clone title enters these columns. Within a book the two dimension ratings average over the same audience (the two rating counts are nearly identical within title), so columns (3) and (6) equal the difference of the two dimension columns and net out any book-level factor. Book controls: log rating volume, runtime, self-published, series. Standard errors, clustered by author, in parentheses. Restricting columns (4)–(6) to identity-verified authors gives  $-0.670$  (0.041) in column (6); with publisher fixed effects on the 559 titles of the 51 publishers that carry clone titles, the clone–human within-book gap is  $0.004$  (0.033). AI = Audible Virtual Voice; a licensed voice clone is an authorized replica of a professional narrator, an anonymous voice any other AI narration. \* $p < .10$ ; \*\* $p < .05$ ; \*\*\* $p < .01$ .

565. Among the anonymous titles, 64.6% are self-published and 22.3% are by authors with an earlier human-narrated audiobook; the clones are the mirror image, none self-published and 62.3% by such incumbent authors.

The author’s reputation does not soften the discount. On human-narrated books the within-book gap is nearly flat in the author’s prior human-narrated catalog ( $-0.003$  per log point of prior ratings); on AI-narrated books it widens roughly ten times faster ( $-0.029$ ; Online Appendix A.2): reputation lifts Story ratings on these books, but not the AI’s Performance. Established authors face, if anything, a larger discount.

The clone channel is small and young, and I read it as early evidence. Of its 565 titles, 68 enter the analysis sample; 27.1% of the 2025 clone cohort has reached five ratings on both dimensions, and only 12.6% of the 374 titles released in the first half of 2026 have been rated at all. With that caveat, the evidence points the same way: in the analysis sample, clone books average 4.60 on Performance against 4.58 on Story; Table 2 finds no statistically significant discount on any dimension; and

**Figure 4** Share of Books Reaching Cumulative-Ratings Thresholds, 2024–2025 Cohorts



*Note.* Share of books whose rating count reaches each threshold, 2024–2025 release cohorts (71,899 human-narrated and 50,817 AI-narrated books). Counts are cumulative as of July 2026. AI = Audible Virtual Voice.

against the same publishers’ human-narrated books the within-book gap differs by 0.004 (note to Table 2). For the twelve narrators with rated books both in their own voice and through a clone (218 books), the within-narrator Performance difference is 0.005: imprecise, but the confidence interval rules out a discount of the anonymous-channel size (Online Appendix A.4). The parity bundles a carried-over voice, loyal audiences, and publisher curation; my data do not separate them.

### 3.4. Absorption Without Breakout

Figure 4 tracks the 2024–2025 release cohorts across cumulative-ratings thresholds. The new supply is absorbed: 61.1% of AI-narrated releases attract at least one rating, against 94.8% of human-narrated releases. It does not break out: 6.7% of AI-narrated books reach twenty ratings against 40.2% of human-narrated books; 1.7% against 22.2% reach fifty; and 0.1% against 7.2% reach two hundred. Rating counts fold in the propensity to rate as well as listening, so these are reach measures rather than usage; no plausible difference in that propensity, however, spans the seventy-fold gap at the two-hundred-rating threshold. Nearly half of the market’s new English-language releases are AI-narrated (Figure 1); almost none becomes a widely rated book.

## 4. Discussion

My study examines the first two and a half years of labeled AI narration on Audible, using the complete catalog and ratings that price the narration and the writing of each book side by side. The central pattern is one of containment: the discount is large, but it stops at the dimension the AI performs.

Experiments that hold quality fixed and vary only the label find aversion to AI provision even at identical performance (Longoni et al. 2019); yet the same literature shows that the response is not uniform: it can favor the algorithm (Logg et al. 2019), it concentrates in subjective and hedonic domains (Castelo et al. 2019, Longoni and Cian 2022), and, within a single product, it attaches to symbolic rather than functional components (Granulo et al. 2021). At census scale, the market's response has precisely this structure: the discount, whatever its mixture of a genuine quality gap and a reaction to the visible label, lands on the dimension the AI performs and leaves the author's dimension nearly untouched. A perception experiment on human and AI audiobook narration points the same way at the individual level: it finds human and AI narration rated nearly alike, and its authors attribute an audiobook's value chiefly to the text, treating the voice as a functional medium rather than the locus of artistic value (Ahrens-Schwabe et al. 2026). A label response that devalued the whole product would have to appear in Story ratings at comparable size; Story moves by at most a tenth as much. A response driven by the label as such should likewise surface among licensed clones, which are disclosed just as plainly; on early evidence it does not. The response behaves less like a blanket verdict on the technology and more like one confined to the dimension the AI performs.

The discount is not borne evenly. It falls on the anonymous channel: overwhelmingly self-published titles by authors without an earlier human-narrated audiobook, the suppliers whose entry the technology enabled in the first place. Reputation does not offset it: an author's name is a brand

built on writing, and nothing in it certifies narration ([Aaker and Keller 1990](#)); the discount widens rather than narrows with the author's prior catalog. The result is a flood that is absorbed but does not break out. Earlier digitization shocks let cheap entry turn unpromising creative goods into surprise hits and enlarged the market's stock of winners ([Waldfogel 2017](#), [Aguiar and Waldfogel 2018](#)). The AI-narrated flood has not opened that channel, and early industry evidence from music and games suggests the same shape across creative markets ([Deezer 2026](#), [Game Oracle 2026](#)).

The licensed-clone channel points to where this market may adjust. A professional narrator's name is a reputational asset, and licensing lets that asset travel with the technology rather than against it ([Tadelis 1999](#)): clone titles, though few, show no counterpart to the anonymous channel's discount, and the channel is growing quickly, from three titles in 2024 to 188 in 2025 and 374 in the first half of 2026. The economics are familiar: superstar markets arise where technology extends a performer's limited personal reach ([Rosen 1981](#)), and a licensed clone relaxes the one constraint recording left in place, the narrator's own hours. Whether the parity reflects the carried-over voice, loyal audiences, or the publishers who curate the channel, my data cannot say; at its current size, the channel supplies early evidence, not a verdict.

The pattern has implications on three fronts. For platforms, the instrument matters as much as the label: Audible pairs disclosure with ratings that price the AI's contribution separately, and that pairing is what makes the market's response legible; as the transparency obligations of the EU AI Act take effect in August 2026 ([European Union 2024](#)), attribute-level feedback is a natural complement to disclosure. For publishers and authors, the results on who bears the discount locate the lever: what travels with a title is not the author's name but the narrator's, and licensing an established voice appears, on early evidence, to restore what an author's reputation cannot. For regulators, the finding tempers the algorithm-aversion evidence that shapes expectations about AI labeling: disclosure in this market produced no blanket rejection, but a precise, attribute-level response.

My limitations follow from the design. The census is an equilibrium snapshot: authors decide which books get an AI voice, and nothing in the data is randomized. The within-author comparison holds the author fixed, and the Story dimension bounds what manuscript selection can explain. My estimates therefore describe the market as it operates, not what would happen if a given book were switched to an AI voice. That within-author comparison rests on the incumbent authors who publish in both regimes, a minority in a market whose AI titles come mostly from new authors, for whom the pooled estimate and the Story diagnostic carry the weight. A book also enters the rating analysis only after five ratings on each dimension, a bar AI-narrated titles clear less often, so the analyzed books are more heavily rated than the catalog as a whole. The catalog is observed live in July 2026 and covers the English-language market, so delisted titles are invisible, earlier vintages are undercounted, non-English AI narration is out of scope, and each book's ratings arrive as a lifetime average rather than a time path. And ratings are evaluations volunteered by consumers who chose the book: they show how a self-selected audience prices the two contributions, not demand, prices paid, or welfare.

The design anticipates its second wave. A rating-only rescan of the same universe, scheduled for August 2026, turns the census into a panel. It will show whether the Performance discount persists as cohorts age, give a first direct look at survival and delisting, and measure how absorption behaves as AI entry keeps climbing. A weekly crawl of new releases adds a forward entry series untouched by survivorship, and the rescan will also show whether clone parity survives the channel's growth. If it does, the pattern of this market's first years would sharpen into a division of labor, anonymous AI absorbed at the low end and licensed identity carrying value through, and the scarce input in a market suddenly full of voices would be not narration but a name.

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